



Butler Medal, 1864

Instituted by Major General Benjamin Butler in 1864 to honor the bravery of Black American troops, the Butler Medal was the only one ever struck for Black troops. It is inscribed: "Freedom will be theirs by the sword."

White attitudes

The first Black volunteers were infused with a profound sense of purpose, which steadied them as a series of challenges were flung their way from within their own army. First, many white soldiers disliked the idea of arming Blacks, and some flatly refused to serve near them. Theodore Upson of the 100th Illinois wrote that "none of our soldiers seem to like the idea of arming the Negroes. Our boys say this is a white man's war and the Negro has no business in it." Recent immigrants to the North took a different tack. As one Irish journalist explained: "I'll let Sambo be murdered instead of meself on any day of the year."